

1. Context and Motivation

The Digital Services Act (DSA) establishes a harmonized framework for platform accountability, mandating that Very Large Online Platforms (VLOPs) submit detailed "Statements of Reasons" (SoRs) for every content moderation decision to the public Digital Service Act (DSA) Transparency Database. Early empirical studies have leveraged this unprecedented dataset to establish moderation baselines, revealing vast disparities in automated enforcement between platforms like TikTok and X (Drolsbach et. al., 2024), while also exposing significant reporting inconsistencies and a lack of adaptive moderation strategies during the 2024 European Parliament elections (Shahi et. al., 2025).

However, existing literature has not yet addressed the moderation dynamics of the 2025 German Federal Snap Election, nor the methodological challenge posed by the database's structural break between API schema v1 and v2 in July 2025. This thesis bridges this gap by developing a harmonized taxonomy mapping to integrate the incompatible category schemas, enabling a longitudinal analysis of how platform affordances (video vs. text) shaped algorithmic governance during this high-salience political crisis.

Proposed Title: *Moderation Dynamics in Transition*

2. Research Questions and Hypotheses

The study is guided by Media Affordance Theory (Bucher & Helmond, 2017) and Agenda-Setting Theory (McCombs & Shaw, 1972; Feezell, 2018):

- **RQ1 (Comparative Architecture):** To what extent does platform modality (video vs. text) shape both the distribution of removal categories and the reliance on automated decision-making, and what does this imply for the comparability and granularity of DSA transparency reporting?
 - *Hypothesis 1:* Driven by platform modality, TikTok (video) is expected to exhibit significantly higher automation rates in visually mediated harm categories compared to X (text). This reliance on automation is hypothesized to correlate with a reduction in reporting granularity, creating a systemic risk for the comparability of cross-platform transparency reports.
- **RQ2 (Event Dynamics):** To what extent does a high-salience political event trigger a shift in moderation intensity and automation reliance, and does increased automation during event periods correspond to a reduction in reporting granularity?
 - *Hypothesis 2:* Following the principle of "Event-Dependency," the 2025 snap election will trigger a statistically significant increase in moderation intensity and automation reliance. It is hypothesized that this "content burst" forces platforms to prioritize processing speed over detail, resulting in a measurable reduction in reporting granularity during the election period compared to the annual baseline.

3. Research Methodology

This thesis employs a quantitative, data-driven approach using the DSA Transparency Database.

- **Data Source & Scope:** Extraction of moderation records for the period of January 1st to December 31st, 2025, filtering for the territorial scope of Germany. Records are included in the analysis if the *territorial_scope* attribute contains the country code "DE". In cases where moderation actions are applied across multiple EEA territories (multilateral scope), the record is treated as part of the German moderation baseline, as the restriction directly impacts the German information environment.
- **Longitudinal Data Harmonization:** To contextualize the election within the full year, the structural break in the DSA database, caused by the transition from API v1 (fixed single-category schema) to API v2 (granular multi-labeling schema) on July 1, 2025, must be bridged. Since new v2 categories (e.g., "Cyber Violence") lack 1:1 equivalents in the old schema, a **unified classification taxonomy** will be developed. To maintain comparability, v2 records with multiple labels will be processed using a **Primary Category Assignment** based on a predefined severity hierarchy. All categories will be clustered into established v1 "Super-Clusters" using a formal **Mapping Protocol** that cross-references semantic definitions against official DSA legal guidance to ensure objectivity and replicability. This ensures a robust longitudinal baseline despite the schema evolution identified by Groesch et al. (2026). This taxonomy alignment serves as a necessary technical preprocessing step to ensure a valid longitudinal baseline; it is not a standalone research objective, but a prerequisite for analyzing the governance shifts identified in the RQs.
- **Event Study (The "Clean" Phase):** The core analysis of the election period (Jan/Feb 2025) relies on consistent API v1 data. Absolute deletion numbers will be normalized as "Deletions per 1,000 Monthly Active Users (MAU)" based on official DSA user reports to ensure cross-platform comparability.
- **Algorithmic Governance:** The automation dimension of both RQs is addressed by extracting the *decision_automated* attribute to compute the monthly proportion of fully automated vs. human-in-the-loop decisions for TikTok and X. This metric operationalizes reporting granularity and allows for comparative assessment of governance behavior across both the platform modality and event period analyses.

4. Preliminary Outline

1. Introduction

1.1 Motivation: Content Moderation as a Black Box, 1.2 Problem Statement: The 2025 Snap Election and Data Discontinuities, 1.3 Objectives and Structure

2. Theoretical Background

2.2.1 The DSA Transparency Regime and Accountability, 2.2 Media Affordance Theory: Modality (Video vs. Text), 2.3 Agenda-Setting Theory: Event Dynamics and Salience, 2.4 Algorithmic Governance: Automation and the "Human-in-the-Loop" (Gorwa et al., 2020).

3. Data and Methodology

3.1 Dataset Description: The DSA Transparency Database, 3.2 Taxonomy Alignment: Methodological Harmonization of API v1/v2, 3.3 Research Design: Event Study (Q1 2025) vs. Annual Baseline

4. Empirical Analysis

4.1 Cross-Platform Comparison: Modality, Removal Categories, and Automation Patterns (TikTok vs. X), 4.2 The Election Effect: Moderation Intensity, Automation Reliance, and Reporting Granularity in Jan/Feb 2025

5. Discussion

5.1 Interpreting Differences through the Lens of Affordances, 5.2 Critical Evaluation of DSA Data Quality, 5.3 Limitations, 5.4 Implications for Platform Governance

6. Conclusion

References

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